

Power of Interest
Safeguarding Policy

Version: 0.2

Approved by: Alan Broad

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Review date:

Introduction

Purpose

Our charitable activities include working with vulnerable people. The purpose of this policy is to protect them and provide stakeholders and the public with the overarching principles that guide our approach in doing so.

The Board appoints a Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) responsible for receiving safeguarding concerns, coordinating responses, maintaining safeguarding records and liaising with statutory agencies where appropriate.

Definitions

Vulnerable people: those under the age of 18 (hereafter ‘child’) and vulnerable adults

Vulnerable adults: (all under 18) and vulnerable adults. An adult at risk is a person aged 18 or over who has needs for care and support, is experiencing or is at risk of abuse or neglect, and because of those needs is unable to protect themselves.

Vulnerability: being especially susceptible to harm due to personal circumstances.

Safeguarding: Protecting children from abuse, neglect, exploitation and harm, and promoting their welfare.

Youth Advisory (non-voting)Trustee: A trustee under the age of 16

Applicability

Partner organisations will be required to have their own safeguarding procedures that must, as a minimum, meet the standards outlined below, and include any additional legal or regulatory requirements specific to their work. These include, but are not limited to other [UK regulators](#), if applicable.

Principles

We believe that:

- Nobody who is involved in our work should ever experience abuse, harm, neglect or exploitation.
- We all have a responsibility to promote the welfare of all of our beneficiaries, staff and volunteers, to keep them safe and to work in a way that protects them.
- We all have a collective responsibility for creating a culture in which our people not only feel safe, but also able to speak up, if they have any concerns.

Types of Abuse

Abuse can take many forms, such as physical, psychological or emotional, financial, sexual or institutional abuse, including neglect and exploitation. Signs that may indicate the different types of abuse are at Appendix 1.

Reporting Concerns

If a crime is in progress, or an individual in immediate danger, call the police, as you would in any other circumstances. Where a child is believed to be at immediate risk of significant harm, Children's Social Care should also be contacted without delay in accordance with local safeguarding procedures.

If you are a beneficiary, or member of the public, make your concerns known to a member of our team, who will alert a senior member of the charity.

For members of the charity, make your concerns known to your supervisor or any member of the board. If you feel unable to do so, speak to a trustee.

The trustees are mindful of their reporting obligations to the Charity Commission in respect of Serious Incident Reporting and, if applicable, other regulators. They are aware of the Government guidance on handling safeguarding allegations.

Responsibilities

Trustees. This safeguarding policy will be reviewed and approved by the Board annually.

Trustees are aware of and will comply with the Charity Commission guidance on safeguarding and protecting people and also the 10 actions trustee boards need to take to ensure good safeguarding governance.

A lead trustee/committee will be given responsibility for the oversight of all aspects of safety, including whistleblowing and H&SW. This will include:

- Creating a culture of respect, in which everyone feels safe and able to speak up.
- An annual review of safety, with recommendations to the Board.

- Receiving regular reports, to ensure this and related policies are being applied consistently.
- Providing oversight of any lapses in safeguarding
- And ensuring that any issues are properly investigated and dealt with quickly, fairly and sensitively, and any reporting to the Police/statutory authorities is carried out.
- Leading the organisation in a way that makes everyone feels safe and able to speak up.
- Ensuring safeguarding risk assessments are carried out and appropriate action taken to minimise these risks, as part of our risk management processes.
- Ensuring that all relevant checks are carried out in recruiting staff and volunteers.
- Planning programmes/activities to take into account potential safeguarding risks, to ensure these are adequately mitigated.
- Ensuring that all appointments that require DBS clearance and safeguarding training are identified, including the level of DBS and any training required.
- Ensuring that a central register is maintained and subject to regular monitoring to ensure that DBS clearances and training are kept up-to-date.
- Ensuring that safeguarding requirements (eg DBS) and responsibilities are reflected in job descriptions, appraisal objectives and personal development plans, as appropriate.
- Risk assessments where DBS is not legally available.

- Listening and engaging, beneficiaries, staff, volunteers and others and involving them as appropriate.
- Responding to any concerns sensitively and acting quickly to address these.
- Ensuring that personal data is stored and managed in a safe way that is compliant with data protection regulations, including valid consent to use any imagery or video.
- Making staff, volunteers and others aware of:
 - Our safeguarding procedures and their specific safeguarding responsibilities on induction, with regular updates/reminders, as necessary.
 - The signs of potential abuse and how to report these.

Everyone. To be aware of our procedures, undertake any necessary training, be aware of the risks and signs of potential abuse and, if you have concerns, to report these immediately (see above).

Fundraising

We will ensure that:

- We comply with the Code of Fundraising Practice, including fundraising that involves children.
- Staff and volunteers are made aware of the Institute of Fundraising guidance on keeping fundraising safe and the NCVO Guidance on vulnerable people and fundraising.

- Our fundraising material is accessible, clear and ethical, including not placing any undue pressure on individuals to donate.
- We do not either solicit nor accept donations from anyone whom we know or think may not be competent to make their own decisions.
- We are sensitive to any particular need that a donor may have.

Donors in Vulnerable Circumstances

Safeguarding duties include working with potentially vulnerable donors.

- Fundraisers must treat donors fairly, enabling them to make an informed decision, particularly those in vulnerable circumstances.
- Vulnerability is defined as being especially susceptible to harm due to personal circumstances.
- Individuals under 18 or adults lacking capacity are automatically considered vulnerable.
- Fundraisers must not exploit lack of knowledge, need for support or vulnerable circumstances.
- If a donor cannot make an informed decision, donations must not be accepted and must be returned if later discovered.
- Fundraising communications should be clear and inclusive, with adjustments for accessibility.
- Staff should be trained to engage respectfully and identify signs such as difficulty understanding, communicating or weighing decisions.

Online Safety

We will identify and manage online risks by ensuring:

- Volunteers, staff and trustees understand how to keep themselves safe online. We may use high privacy settings and password access to meetings to support this.
- The online services we provide are suitable for our users. For example, use age restrictions and offer password protection to help keep people safe.
- The services we use and/or provide are safe and in line with our code of conduct.
- We protect people's personal data and follow data protection legislation.
- We have permission to display any images on our website or social media accounts, including consent from an individual, parent, etc.
- We clearly explain how users can report online concerns. Concerns may be reported using this policy, or direct to a social media provider using their reporting process. If you are unsure, you can contact one of these organisations, who will help you.
- We have adopted and comply with the Charity AI Ethics & Governance Framework.
- We follow the Charity AI Best Practice Guidance on mitigating the risk of deepfakes and also the ethical use of imagery.

AI Safety

We recognise the growing use of AI and are committed to ensuring our use is both safe and ethical, and to safeguard our community from abuse by others using AI.

- We have adopted and comply with the [Charity AI Ethics & Governance Framework](#), which sets out best practice for responsible AI use, including

transparency, accountability, and minimising risks to vulnerable individuals which can be found at Appendix 2.

- All staff, volunteers, and trustees are required to follow [Charity AI Best Practice Guidance](#) on mitigating risks such as [deepfakes](#) and the [ethical use of imagery](#).
- We regularly review our AI systems and processes to identify and address potential safeguarding risks, ensuring that personal data is protected and that AI tools do not facilitate abuse, exploitation, or harm.
- We do not allow the use of AI bots for crisis or emotional support, or to provide professional advice, such as medical or legal guidance.
- AI-generated safeguarding reports should always be reviewed by a human decision-maker.

Youth Trustees

Power of Interest welcomes young people into governance roles as part of its charitable purpose. Youth trustees are supported by experienced adult trustees and will not be expected to undertake safeguarding responsibilities, manage confidential safeguarding cases.

Appropriate support, supervision and safeguarding arrangements will be provided at all times.

Working With Other Organisations

In working with other organisations, including any grant making, we will comply with [Charity Commission guidance](#) by carrying out relevant due diligence and having a written agreement that sets out:

- Our relationship.

- The role of each organisation.
- Monitoring and reporting arrangements.

Signed

Name

Date

Appendix 1 - Signs of Abuse

Physical Abuse.

- bruises, black eyes, welts, lacerations, and rope marks.
- broken bones.
- open wounds, cuts, punctures, untreated injuries in various stages of healing.
- broken eyeglasses/frames, or any physical signs of being punished or restrained.
- laboratory findings of either an overdose or under dose medications.
- individual's report being hit, slapped, kicked, or mistreated.
- vulnerable adult's sudden change in behaviour.
- the caregiver's refusal to allow visitors to see a vulnerable adult alone.

Sexual Abuse.

- bruises around the breasts or genital area.
- unexplained venereal disease or genital infections.

- unexplained vaginal or anal bleeding.
- torn, stained, or bloody underclothing.
- an individual's report of being sexually assaulted or raped.

Mental Mistreatment/Emotional Abuse.

- being emotionally upset or agitated.
- being extremely withdrawn and non-communicative or non-responsive.
- nervousness around certain people.
- an individual's report of being verbally or mentally mistreated.

Neglect.

- dehydration, malnutrition, untreated bed sores and poor personal hygiene.
- unattended or untreated health problems.
- hazardous or unsafe living condition (e.g., improper wiring, no heat or running water).
- unsanitary and unclean living conditions (e.g., dirt, fleas, lice on person, soiled bedding, faecal/urine smell, inadequate clothing).
- an individual's report of being mistreated.
- Self-Neglect.
- dehydration, malnutrition, untreated or improperly attended medical conditions, and poor personal hygiene.
- hazardous or unsafe living conditions.
- unsanitary or unclean living quarters (e.g., animal/insect infestation, no functioning toilet, faecal or urine smell).
- inappropriate and/or inadequate clothing, lack of the necessary medical aids.
- grossly inadequate housing or homelessness.

- inadequate medical care, not taking prescribed medications properly.

Exploitation.

- sudden changes in bank account or banking practice, including an unexplained withdrawal of large sums of money.
- adding additional names on bank signature cards.
- unauthorized withdrawal of funds using an ATM card.
- abrupt changes in a will or other financial documents.
- unexplained disappearance of funds or valuable possessions.
- bills unpaid despite the money being available to pay them.
- forging a signature on financial transactions or for the titles of possessions.
- sudden appearance of previously uninvolved relatives claiming rights to a vulnerable adult's possessions.
- unexplained sudden transfer of assets to a family member or someone outside the family.
- providing services that are not necessary.
- individual's report of exploitation.

Appendix 2 – AI Risks to Vulnerable People

Threats to vulnerable people include:

- Forming emotional dependence on chatbots.
- Receiving harmful or manipulative advice from an AI bot.
- Using AI for emotional or crisis support, self-diagnosis of medical issues or legal/financial decisions.
- Being scammed or misled by AI generated messages, voices, or images created by others.